

睇戲

tai2 hei3



Real-Life Cantonese: Going to the Cinema

Learn how Cantonese is actually used on a casual trip to
the cinema 🍿

LEVEL A1-B1

STORY + 21 WORDS

6 EXERCISES

WHAT'S INSIDE

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reusable patterns → real-life notes → 6 exercises → answer key

Read it once, all in Cantonese

Don't worry about every word yet. Read it through, then work sentence by sentence.

今日我約咗朋友去睇一套我一直好想睇嘅戲。去到戲院嘅時候，一個人都有，因為今日係平日。我哋預先已經買咗飛，所以去到淨係買嘢食。我哋買咗爆谷同埋嘢飲，買完之後我哋就準備入場啦。好緊張呀！睇完之後我覺得好好睇，但係好血腥，搞到我好唔舒服。唔知你哋又睇過呢套戲未呢？留言話我知。

THE WHOLE STORY IN JYUTPING

gam1 jat6 ngo5 joek3 zo2 pang4 jau5 heoi3 tai2 jat1 tou3 ngo5 jat1 zik6 hou2 soeng2 tai2 ge3 heoi3. heoi3 dou3 heoi3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, jat1 go3 jan4 dou1 mou5, jan1 wai6 gam1 jat6 hai6 ping4 jat6. ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 ji5 ging1 maai5 zo2 fei1, so2 ji5 heoi3 dou3 zing6 hai6 maai5 je5 sik6. ngo5 dei6 maai5 zo2 baau3 guk1 tung4 maai4 je5 jam2, maai5 jyun4 zi1 hau6 ngo5 dei6 zau6 zeon2 bei6 jap6 coeng4 laa1. hou2 gan2 zoeng1 aa3! tai2 jyun4 zi1 hau6 ngo5 gok3 dak1 hou2 hou2 tai2, daan6 hai6 hou2 hyut3 sing1, gaau2 dou3 ngo5 hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6. m4 zi1 nei5 dei6 jau6 tai2 gwo3 ni1 tou3 heoi3 mei6 ne1? lau4 jin4 waa6 ngo5 zi1.

In English

Today I made plans with a friend to see a movie I'd been wanting to watch for ages. When we got to the cinema, there was nobody there, because today's a weekday. We had already bought the tickets in advance, so when we got there we only had to buy food. We bought popcorn and drinks, and after that we got ready to go in. So exciting! Afterwards I thought it was really good, but it was very gory, which made me feel pretty uncomfortable. I wonder — have you guys seen this movie yet? Let me know in the comments.

Sentence by sentence

Cantonese first, Jyutping underneath, English last.

1

今日我約咗朋友去睇一套我一直好想睇嘅戲。

gam1 jat6 ngo5 joek3 zo2 pang4 jau5 heoi3 tai2 jat1 tou3 ngo5 jat1 zik6 hou2 soeng2 tai2 ge3 hei3.

Today I made plans with a friend to see a movie I'd been wanting to watch for ages.

2

去到戲院嘅時候，一個人都有，因為今日係平日。

heoi3 dou3 hei3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, jat1 go3 jan4 dou1 mou5, jan1 wai6 gam1 jat6 hai6 ping4 jat6.

When we got to the cinema, there was nobody there, because today's a weekday.

3

我哋預先已經買咗飛，所以去到淨係買嘢食。

ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 ji5 ging1 maai5 zo2 fei1, so2 ji5 heoi3 dou3 zing6 hai6 maai5 je5 sik6.

We had already bought the tickets in advance, so when we got there we only had to buy food.

4

我哋買咗爆谷同埋嘢飲，買完之後我哋就準備入場啦。

ngo5 dei6 maai5 zo2 baau3 guk1 tung4 maai4 je5 jam2, maai5 jyun4 zi1 hau6 ngo5 dei6 zau6 zeon2 bei6 jap6 coeng4 laa1.

We bought popcorn and drinks, and after that we got ready to go in.

5

好緊張呀！

hou2 gan2 zoeng1 aa3!

So exciting!

6

睇完之後我覺得好好睇，但係好血腥，搞到我好唔舒服。

tai2 jyun4 zi1 hau6 ngo5 gok3 dak1 hou2 hou2 tai2, daan6 hai6 hou2 hyut3 sing1, gaau2 dou3 ngo5 hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6.

Afterwards I thought it was really good, but it was very gory, which made me feel pretty uncomfortable.

7

唔知你哋又睇過呢套戲未呢？

m4 zi1 nei5 dei6 jau6 tai2 gwo3 ni1 tou3 hei3 mei6 ne1?

I wonder — have you guys seen this movie yet?

8

留言話我知。

lau4 jin4 waa6 ngo5 zi1.

Let me know in the comments.

VOCABULARY

Key words from the story 🍿

All 21 words, all things you'd really hear in Hong Kong.

約

joek3

to make plans / arrange to meet

預先

jyu6 sin1

in advance / beforehand

約咗朋友

joek3 zo2 pang4 jau5

made plans with a friend

💡 約咗 (joek3 zo2) already tells you the plan is made.

已經

ji5 ging1

already

戲

hei3

movie / film

飛

fei1

ticket

💡 The everyday spoken word for a ticket — cinema, concert, ferry, anything.

戲院

hei3 jyun2

cinema

淨係

zing6 hai6

only / just

一套戲

jat1 tou3 hei3

one movie

💡 Movies are counted with 套 (tou3), never 個 (go3).

嘢食

je5 sik6

food (things to eat)

平日

ping4 jat6

weekday

爆谷

baau3 guk1

popcorn

嘢飲

je5 jam2

drinks (things to drink)

準備

zeon2 bei6

to get ready / prepare

搞到

gaau2 dou3

to end up causing / to make (someone feel)

入場

jap6 coeng4

to go in (cinema, venue, stadium)

唔舒服

m4 syu1 fuk6

unwell / uncomfortable

緊張

gan2 zoeng1

nervous / excited



Covers nerves and excitement — the good kind of butterflies too.

睇過

tai2 gwo3

have watched (before)

血腥

hyut3 sing1

gory / bloody

留言

lau4 jin4

to leave a comment

✨ Cantonese you can reuse

Seven structures from the story. Swap in your own words.

PATTERN 1

約咗 + person + 去 + activity

= made plans with someone to...

Your go-to way to say you've arranged something with someone. The person comes first, then the activity.

我約咗朋友去睇戲。

ngo5 joek3 zo2 pang4 jau5 heoi3 tai2 hei3.

I made plans with a friend to watch a movie.

我約咗同事去食飯。

ngo5 joek3 zo2 tung4 si6 heoi3 sik6 faan6.

I made plans with a colleague to go eat.

你約咗邊個去行山？

nei5 joek3 zo2 bin1 go3 heoi3 haang4 saan1?

Who did you arrange to go hiking with?

PATTERN 2

去到 + place + 嘅時候...

= when I / we got to...

Sets the scene. Open the sentence with it, then say what you found there.

去到戲院嘅時候，一個人都有。

heoi3 dou3 hei3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, jat1 go3 jan4 dou1 mou5.

When we got to the cinema, there was nobody there.

去到公司嘅時候，我發現唔見咗電話。

heoi3 dou3 gung1 si1 ge3 si4 hau6, ngo5 faat3 jin6 m4 gin3 zo2 din6 waa2.

When I got to the office, I realised I'd lost my phone.

PATTERN 3

預先 + verb

= do something in advance

Goes right before the verb. Very common with buying, booking and packing.

我哋預先買咗飛。

ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 maai5 zo2 fei1.

We bought the tickets in advance.

記得預先訂枱。

gei3 dak1 jyu6 sin1 deng6 toi2.

Remember to book a table in advance.

PATTERN 4

淨係 + verb / noun

= only / just

Put 淨係 (zing6 hai6) in front of whatever you're limiting — the action, or the thing.

我淨係買咗爆谷。

ngo5 zing6 hai6 maai5 zo2 baau3 guk1.

I only bought popcorn.

我淨係想飲水。

ngo5 zing6 hai6 soeng2 jam2 sei2.

I just want some water.

淨係我一個人去。

zing6 hai6 ngo5 jat1 go3 jan4 heoi3.

I went on my own.

PATTERN 5

verb + 完 + 之後

= after finishing...

完 (jyun4) means the action is finished; 之後 (zi1 hau6) means "after". Together they order your story.

買完之後，我哋就入場。

maai5 jyun4 zi1 hau6, ngo5 dei6 zau6 jap6 coeng4.

After buying everything, we went inside.

食完飯之後我哋去咗散步。

sik6 jyun4 faan6 zi1 hau6 ngo5 dei6 heoi3 zo2 saan3 bou6.

After dinner we went for a walk.

PATTERN 6

搞到 + person + result

= ended up making someone...

For unplanned side effects — something happened, and this was the knock-on effect.

套戲好血腥，搞到我好唔舒服。

tou3 hei3 hou2 hyut3 sing1, gaau2 dou3 ngo5 hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6.

The movie was so gory it made me feel really uncomfortable.

佢遲咗，搞到我哋等咗半個鐘。

keoi5 ci4 zo2, gaau2 dou3 ngo5 dei6 dang2 zo2 bun3 go3 zung1.

He was late, so we ended up waiting half an hour.

PATTERN 7

verb + 過 (… 未 ?)

= have you ever...?

過 (gwo3) marks experience. Add 未 (mei6) at the end and it becomes "...yet?"

你睇過呢套戲未？

nei5 tai2 gwo3 ni1 tou3 hei3 mei6?

Have you seen this movie yet?

我未去過呢間戲院。

ngo5 mei6 heoi3 gwo3 ni1 gaan1 hei3 jyun2.

I haven't been to this cinema before.

Little things locals just know 🇭🻜

Why do Hong Kong people say 飛 (fei1)?

飛 (fei1) is the everyday spoken word for a ticket — it comes from the English "fare". You'll hear it far more often than the formal 票 (piu3).

電影飛 *din6 jing2 fei1* — movie ticket

演唱會飛 *jin2 coeng3 wui2 fei1* — concert ticket

買飛 *maai5 fei1* — to buy tickets

嘢 (je5) = "stuff"

Put 嘢 (je5) in front of a verb and you get "things to ____". It saves you naming the exact food or drink.

嘢食 *je5 sik6* — food

嘢飲 *je5 jam2* — drinks

買嘢 *maai5 je5* — to go shopping

17 平日 (ping4 jat6) is a real plan

Cinema tickets are cheaper on weekdays in Hong Kong, so going 平日 (ping4 jat6) is a normal money-saving move — and the hall is often nearly empty.

平日 *ping4 jat6* — weekday

週末 *zau1 mut6* — weekend

一個人都有 *jat1 go3 jan4 dou1 mou5* — not a single person there

PRACTICE

Your turn

Every Cantonese word here comes with its Jyutping, so you can do all six exercises even if you don't read characters yet. 加油 (gaa1 jau4)!

Exercise 1

Match the vocabulary

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Cantonese word.

1. 戲院
hei3 jyun2

2. 飛
fei1

3. 爆谷
baau3 guk1

4. 平日
ping4 jat6

5. 血腥
hyut3 sing1

6. 留言
lau4 jin4

A. weekday

B. to leave a comment

C. ticket

D. gory

E. cinema

F. popcorn

Exercise 2

Fill in the blank

Write the missing word — characters or Jyutping, both are fine.

1. 我哋預先買咗 _____，所以唔使排隊。

ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 maai5 zo2 _____, so2 ji5 m4 sai2 paai4 deoi2.

We bought the _____ in advance, so we didn't have to queue.

2. 去到戲院嘅時候，一個人都 _____。

heoi3 dou3 hei3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, jat1 go3 jan4 dou1 _____.

When we got to the cinema, there _____ nobody there.

3. 套戲好血腥，_____ 我好唔舒服。

tou3 hei3 hou2 hyut3 sing1, _____ ngo5 hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6.

The movie was so gory it _____ me feel really uncomfortable.

4. 我哋買完嘢食就準備 _____ 啦。

ngo5 dei6 maai5 jyun4 je5 sik6 zau6 zeon2 bei6 _____ laa1.

Once we'd bought the food we got ready to _____.

Exercise 3

Choose the correct answer

1. 「淨係」means:

zing6 hai6

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| ☐ A. already | ☐ B. only |
| ☐ C. together | ☐ D. suddenly |

2. In 買飛, 「飛」means:

maai5 fei1 / fei1

- | | |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| ☐ A. to fly | ☐ B. ticket |
| ☐ C. price | ☐ D. seat |

3. 「平日」means:

ping4 jat6

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ A. a cheap day | ☐ B. a weekday |
| ☐ C. a public holiday | ☐ D. a flat road |

4. 「你睇過呢套戲未？」 is asking:

nei5 tai2 gwo3 ni1 tou3 hei3 mei6?

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ A. Do you want to see this movie? | ☐ B. Have you seen this movie yet? |
| ☐ C. Did you like this movie? | ☐ D. Will you see this movie with me? |

Exercise 4

Put the words in order

Rewrite the pieces as one natural sentence.

1. I made plans with a friend to watch a movie.

朋友

pang4 jau5

我

ngo5

約咗

joek3 zo2

去睇戲

heoi3 tai2 hei3

2. We bought the tickets in advance.

買咗

maai5 zo2

我哋

ngo5 dei6

預先

jyu6 sin1

飛

fei1

3. The movie was so gory it made me feel uncomfortable.

好唔舒服

hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6

搞到

gaau2 dou3

套戲好血腥

tou3 hei3 hou2 hyut3 sing1

我

ngo5

Exercise 5

Complete the sentence

Finish each one your own way, using the patterns from this lesson.

1. 睇完套戲之後，_____。
tai2 jyun4 tou3 hei3 zi1 hau6, _____.
After watching the movie, _____.
-

2. 去到戲院嘅時候，_____。
heoi3 dou3 hei3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, _____.
When I got to the cinema, _____.
-

3. 我約咗 _____ 去 _____。
ngo5 joek3 zo2 _____ heoi3 _____.
I made plans with _____ to _____.
-

Exercise 6



Real-life challenge

Imagine you went to the cinema yesterday. Write five sentences: who you went with, what you watched, what food you bought, whether you liked it, and how it made you feel.

SENTENCE STARTER BANK

我約咗... 去睇戲。 ngo5 joek3 zo2 ... heoi3 tai2 hei3.
I made plans with ... to watch a movie.

我哋預先買咗飛。 ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 maai5 zo2 fei1.
We bought the tickets in advance.

我買咗爆谷同埋嘢飲。 ngo5 maai5 zo2 baau3 guk1 tung4 maai4 je5 jam2.
I bought popcorn and a drink.

我覺得套戲好... ngo5 gok3 dak1 tou3 hei3 hou2 ...
I thought the movie was really ...

搞到我好... gaau2 dou3 ngo5 hou2 ...
It ended up making me feel really ...

ANSWER KEY

Check your work

Try everything first — no peeking!

Exercise 1 — Match the vocabulary

E

戲院

hei3 jyun2

cinema

C

飛

fei1

ticket

F

爆谷

baau3 guk1

popcorn

A

平日

ping4 jat6

weekday

D

血腥

hyut3 sing1

gory

B

留言

lau4 jin4

to leave a comment

Exercise 2 — Fill in the blank

Sentence 1

飛

fei1

Sentence 2

冇

mou5

Sentence 3

搞到

gaau2 dou3

Sentence 4

入場

jap6 coeng4

Exercise 3 — Choose the correct answer

Q1 — B. only

淨係 (zing6 hai6) limits things: 我淨係買咗爆谷 (ngo5 zing6 hai6 maai5 zo2 baau3 guk1) = "I only bought popcorn."

Q2 — B. ticket

飛 (fei1) is the spoken word for a ticket. 買飛 (maai5 fei1) = "to buy tickets".

Q3 — B. a weekday

平日 (ping4 jat6) = a weekday, as opposed to 週末 (zau1 mut6), the weekend.

Q4 — B. Have you seen this movie yet?

Verb + 過 (gwo3) asks about experience, and 未 (mei6) at the end makes it "...yet?"

Exercise 4 — Put the words in order

Sentence 1

我約咗朋友去睇戲。

ngo5 joek3 zo2 pang4 jau5 heoi3 tai2 hei3.

I made plans with a friend to watch a movie.

Sentence 2

我哋預先買咗飛。

ngo5 dei6 jyu6 sin1 maai5 zo2 fei1.

We bought the tickets in advance.

Sentence 3

套戲好血腥，搞到我好唔舒服。

tou3 hei3 hou2 hyut3 sing1, gaau2 dou3 ngo5 hou2 m4 syu1 fuk6.

The movie was so gory it made me feel uncomfortable.

Exercise 5 — Complete the sentence (sample answers)

睇完套戲之後，我哋去咗食宵夜。

tai2 jyun4 tou3 hei3 zi1 hau6, ngo5 dei6 heoi3 zo2 sik6 siu1 je2.

After the movie, we went for a late-night snack.

去到戲院嘅時候，好多人排隊買飛。

heoi3 dou3 hei3 jyun2 ge3 si4 hau6, hou2 do1 jan4 paai4 deoi2 maai5 fei1.

When I got to the cinema, lots of people were queuing for tickets.

我約咗細佬去睇戲。

ngo5 joek3 zo2 sai3 lou2 heoi3 tai2 hei3.

I made plans with my little brother to watch a movie.

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